

**THE OTHER  
JEWEL: Agra Fort**



# The Forgotten City

Why there is much more to historical Agra than the Taj Mahal



**AGRA: THE ARCHITECTURAL  
HERITAGE**  
by LUCY PECK  
Roli  
Price: Rs 295; Pages: 186

■ By Sam Miller

It is a paradox that Agra, home to the world's most famous monument, is also a forgotten city. It has become an in-and-out destination for tourists, who visit the Taj Mahal and the fort on day trips from Delhi, or who might just stay one night en route to Jaipur. Most don't want to remain longer, unwilling to spend any more time braving the bronchitic pollution or dealing with India's most persistent tourist touts. As a result, they miss out on a spectacular range of less famous Mughal monuments and gardens scattered throughout the city, as well as some fascinating buildings from the British period.

This book is a historical guide to the architecture of Agra and Fatehpur Sikri from the times of Babur to the 1930s. Lucy Peck uses a combination of historical and architectural narrative, photographs, maps and line drawings to describe a quite different Agra from the one most visitors know. The Taj Mahal, for instance, is covered in detail, but Peck's is not a traditional

account. She dismisses many of the myths that surround the building of the mausoleum, and repeated by some guides, including claims that it was originally a Hindu palace, that the builders were killed or maimed so they that could not build another such building, and that Shah Jahan intended to build a Black Taj on the other side of the Yamuna. She also explains how the Taj Mahal was provided with a water supply, and gives a detailed account of the neglected buildings that surround the mausoleum complex. She wanders through the older Mughal and British parts of the city, describing and photographing neglected princely tombs, 19th-century factories, and Art Deco buildings from the 1930s.

This book successfully puts historical Agra in both its original and its modern context. Peck encourages visitors to take to the streets, and make sense for themselves, of the overlapping identities of a city whose fortunes have risen and fallen so often over the last 500 years. It's an approach to understanding the urban heritage which is sorely needed in several other Indian cities—Lucknow and Ahmedabad are obvious examples—where lesser monuments of the past are imperilled, and a complex urban history needs clear and accurate explanation. ■

## Cuttack Blues

Homecoming goes terribly wrong in this novel set in Orissa



**THE MAHANADI DREAM**  
by SUBHAKANTA BEHERA  
Indialog Publications  
Price: Rs 225  
Pages: 214

■ By Bunny Suraiya

Arun is an MBA. He is either 40 years old (page 12) or 34 years old (page 24). He has given up his cushy job (this is the way it is always described) with an MNC in Delhi to return to his hometown, Cuttack, so that he can be with his near and dear, by which term he refers to his parents and his old school friends. After 10 years away, he notices that "nothing had changed" in his city. Then again, he is happy to see that "fancy streetlights had been installed; many modern buildings...had come up.... Several retail stores too had opened". In Delhi, Arun had "developed a soft corner" for Saira, his neighbour's daughter, but although "Saira did not step back in sending him signals of love", their relationship was doomed. Saira was gangraped and set on fire by hooligans in her college. We know this because despite having suffered over 90 per cent burns Saira managed to give a remarkably lengthy and lucid statement to the authorities before she "succumbed". Arun, on the other hand, "was at a loss of words".

If you are tired of such plodding sentences, to say nothing of an idiosyncratic use of words, this book is not for you. Every sentence is written in the same reading-primer style, liberally laced with all the clichés ever invented, and leavened only by the odd transcendence into unintentional hilarity. As, for example, when Arun, faced by an oncoming truck, "tactfully swung his scooter to the left thus avoiding a head on collision". Or, my favourite bit: "Even though Rekha had lost her virginity earlier, her breasts were still strong and pert; her private parts were still like that of a virgin's. Arun was taken over by passion." Bravo! This reviewer was taken over by giggles. ■